letting the supporters down. The one person who'd said all along that he thought we could win the game was the manager. Sven's never one for talking big to the press before games but, since taking over, every time he'd been asked about the Germany game, he'd said that he thought we were good enough to win. Maybe his confidence, over the months and, then, in the days leading up to the game on the first of September, found its way into the players' own minds without us even realizing it.

Whatever the reason, by the time we were sitting down to dinner at the hotel in Munich on the Friday night before the game, I found myself looking around and listening to conversations and wondering if I could ever remember being with an England team that seemed in such a positive state of mind. I had my own doubts about the game, but they were to do with whether or not I'd be fit to play. I went up to my room later and spoke to my mate Dave Gardner. He asked me how I thought we were going to get on. The couple of hours with the rest of the players had convinced me.

'I think we're going to win.'

The silence at the other end of the line told me there wasn't the same kind of confidence back at home. But I wouldn't have said it to Dave if I hadn't believed it. And I wanted to be part of what I thought was going to happen. I was worried that a groin injury I'd picked up playing for United against Aston Villa the week before wasn't going to heal in time. It had turned out not to be as bad a tear as I'd thought when it first happened, so I'd joined up for England training with the rest of the lads although I wasn't fit enough to train with them. I had a week on my own, getting treatment, hoping for the best and hating every minute of it. Being captain made it even worse: I wanted to be involved in everything. Instead, the first time I was able to work with everybody else was at the stadium, late in the afternoon before that Friday night dinner.

I went out half an hour early with Gary Lewin and Alan Smith from the England medical team to check my fitness: running, turning, hitting dead balls. It's a strange feeling, even more so with a place in the team for such a big game at stake. You want to stretch yourself to make sure you're strong enough to play and won't let anybody down. At the same time, you can't help but hold back a little because you don't want to breakdown at the last minute and miss out on your chance. Anyway, Gary and Alan were happy and gave me the all-clear to join in with the main session. It felt great: the rest of the squad were in such good form. I found myself wishing we could have a go at the Germans there and then.